Reclaiming Place Through Symbolic Geographies: Visual Resistance on Palestinian Instagram

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Abstract

This study examines how Palestinian Instagram users deploy visual symbols to construct *symbolic geographies*—visual and textual claims to space and belonging shaped by cultural memory, emotional connection, and political contestation. Drawing on 9,126 posts from 834 users, we analyze how visual storytelling operates as a means of simulating physical presence under conditions of occupation, censorship, and algorithmic suppression. Through multimodal analysis, we identify three overarching communicative goals: (1) claiming contested spaces through visual–textual pairings that assert spatial belonging; (2) coding resistance through strategic ambiguity that subverts moderation while maintaining narrative coherence; and (3) collective remembering through temporal anchoring and visual repetition that sustain national memory over time. These practices function as a form of countervisuality, generating affective and communicative infrastructures that resist geopolitical and epistemic erasure. Our findings extend research on digital placemaking, memory activism, and visual politics by showing how ordinary users transform ephemeral posts into a networked archive of cultural survival, and by offering a conceptual framework for understanding symbolic geographies as a product of strategic, multimodal storytelling under structural marginalization.

Keywords: Instagram, digital placemaking, violence, framing, social media, protest, countervisuality

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In recent years, digital platforms have become critical tools for political expression, especially within protest movements and grassroots mobilizations. Across movements such as the Arab Spring, Black Lives Matter, and the Sudanese revolution, scholars have shown how activists use social media posts to bypass mainstream media gatekeeping, amplify marginalized voices, and reclaim narrative control (Tufekci, 2017; Jackson et al., 2020). This dynamic also extends to regions experiencing protracted geopolitical conflict and settler-colonial occupation, where platforms serve as a "third place" (Oldenburg, 1999) for digital placemaking—showcasing alternative narratives and sustaining historical continuity (Gordon & de Souza e Silva, 2013; Wilken et al., 2020). In such contested contexts, digital placemaking can operate as a non-confrontational yet politically potent response to algorithmic erasure and stereotyping, offering a means to assert identity, belonging, and memory without direct engagement in hostile discourse.

We focus on digital placemaking during the ongoing Gaza genocide (Amnesty International, 2024; OHCHR, 2024; UN, 2024), which escalated in October 2023 and transformed Instagram into a contested arena of representation. Palestinian users relied on the platform to document lived realities, even as opaque moderation practices allegedly removed or down-ranked large volumes of Arabic content (Magdy et al., 2025). This creates a dual communicative challenge: state pressure to silence dissent and algorithmic suppression that renders vulnerable voices invisible (Gillespie, 2018; Jhaver et al., 2019). Against this backdrop, we ask how Palestinians used social media to assert their voices and reclaim representational space.

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Our approach treats these Instagram posts not only as political messages but also as a visual language—one that encodes meaning through symbols, spatial cues, and aesthetic conventions, and that operates alongside and in interaction with verbal language. While work on social movements has richly examined slogans, speeches, and textual discourse, it has tended to overlook the communicative complexity of visual symbols as meaning-making resources. We contend that these posts contribute to symbolic geographies: emotionally charged, user-generated mappings of place shaped by cultural memory and political affect. As such, they are both linguistic and spatial acts—forms of "talk" rendered in imagery and layout, whose syntax is composition, framing, and sequencing, and whose semantics are rooted in shared cultural codes.

Most scholarship on Palestinian media has examined mainstream press coverage and political discourse, with far less attention to citizen-led visual journalism or to how digital imagery functions as a countervisual dataset for spatial and symbolic reconstruction. Our study addresses these gaps through a multi-method analysis of 9,126 Instagram posts from 834 users participating in a public hashtag campaign to share images of their homes in Palestine during the first six months of the genocide. Our methodological approach attends to both the semantic layers of content—what is shown and said—and the platform logics that shape circulation—how people engage with it. We trace how symbolic geographies are constructed, circulated, and received, identifying three high-level goals that structure this visual work: claiming space, coding resistance, and collective remembering. In foregrounding visual storytelling as a culturally situated form of digital placemaking and as a language in its own right, we show how ordinary users co-produce contested narratives of space, memory, and survival under conditions of infrastructural and political constraint.

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Background

Erasure extends beyond material destruction, constituting the control of visibility, memory, and narrative. As a governing technology, erasure determines whose presence is legible and whose histories endure (Anziska, 2019), whose lives can be rendered absent without consequence (Pappé, 2006); therefore, erasure rewrites reality itself.

Erasure enables the territorial domination of settler colonial powers by normalizing absence and foreclosing alternative claims to space, history, and belonging, as well as extending into the epistemic realm to shape what can be known, narrated, and remembered. In the Palestinian context, erasure occurs across physical and digital terrains. The displacement and fragmentation of Palestinian life have been accompanied by sustained efforts to control memory, visibility, and historical narration. The 1948 Nakba, during which over 700,000 Palestinians were forcibly displaced and hundreds of villages destroyed (Abu Sitta, 2004; Al Jazeera, 2022; Masalha, 1992; Morris, 1987; Pappé, 2006) was systematic project of elimination aimed at consolidating a Jewish-majority state (Khalidi, 2020; Veracini, 2013). Subsequent decades intensified this logic through land confiscation, settlement expansion, and administrative fragmentation, rendering Palestinian space increasingly discontinuous and governed through regimes of restriction and surveillance (Shehadeh, 1985; Makdisi, 2010; Weizman, 2024). Alongside material dispossession, symbolic erasure accompanied territorial control: Arabic place names were replaced, maps redrawn, and depopulated villages overwritten by new national narratives (Amir, 2024; Azaryahu & Golan, 2001; Benvenisti, 2000; Yacobi, 2009).

In the twenty-first century, Palestinian erasure increasingly extends beyond physical territory into digital space, where the settler-colonial “logic of elimination” is furthered through

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surveillance, altered online maps, and social media censorship (Qannam, & Eisheh, 2023). In this sense, erasure increasingly operates not simply as the absence of representation but through the active structuring of knowledge—deciding which histories circulate and which are rendered unintelligible (The Conversation, 2024). For instance, in 2005 the technological governance of Gaza implied that Palestinians were enclosed within privatized telecommunications and surveillance infrastructures (Tawil-Souri, 2012). Social media platforms also act as sites for control and contestation, where algorithmic moderation, content removal, and shadowbanning are reported to disproportionately affect Palestinian voices (Human Rights Watch, 2021).

Resistance to erasure takes many forms; for Palestinians, memory operates as a form of resistance and continuity when physical spaces are destroyed or transformed. Oral histories, storytelling, ritual practices, and material objects – keys, embroidery, domestic artifacts – preserve what Saad (2019) terms “metonymic fragments of home.” These practices assert belonging and political claim in the present, even under conditions of displacement. In digital environments, such acts of remembrance gain renewed political significance: images, videos, and testimonies circulate as claims to visibility and historical truth, challenging regimes that seek to suppress them. As scholars of visual culture note, images do not merely represent events; they shape how events are interpreted and remembered, even as they remain subject to surveillance and control (Barnhurst et al., 2004; Hansen, 2015).

Taken together, these dynamics position digital platforms as contradictory spaces—sites of both erasure and resistance, constraint and possibility. They are arenas in which struggles over memory, presence, and political legitimacy are increasingly negotiated through visual means. Within this terrain, practices of digital activism, countervisuality, and symbolic world-making

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emerge not as peripheral expressions, but as central modes through which Palestinians contest erasure and assert spatial and historical presence.

The following section turns to these dynamics by examining how mediatization, digital activism, and visual resistance shape contemporary practices of countervisuality and digital placemaking. It then introduces symbolic geographies as a conceptual framework for understanding how place, memory, and power are negotiated through digital visual practices.

Mediatization, Digital Activism, and Visual Resistance

This study conceptualizes digital media and activism as socio-technical environments in which power, identity, and spatial relations are continuously produced and contested. It approaches digital activism as a mode of spatial and affective world-making through which histories, attachments, and claims to place are articulated. Visual practices are understood as constitutive of political meaning, shaping how belonging, legitimacy, and memory are produced and contested across digital spaces.

Scholarship on the Palestinian media landscape has long emphasized the political consequences of mediation. Wolfsfeld's (1997) foundational analysis of media and political conflict demonstrated how news institutions structure political visibility, confer legitimacy on certain actors, and marginalize others through routinized journalistic practices. Subsequent work has shown that these asymmetries persist in digital environments, where platforms reconfigure—but do not necessarily democratize—relations of power. Research on digital activism highlights how Palestinian actors navigate platform governance, censorship, and surveillance while mobilizing transnational publics (Siapera, 2014; Monshipouri & Prompichai, 2018). Together, this

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literature demonstrates that media infrastructures function simultaneously as arenas of political possibility and mechanisms of constraint.

More recent scholarship has turned toward the visual dimensions of these dynamics. Studies of citizen journalism, platformed visual activism, and multimodal resistance show how images circulate affect, mobilize publics, and contest dominant narratives of violence and legitimacy (Cervi & Divon, 2023; Jha & Chumbow, 2024; Saputra et al., 2025; Wesam, 2023). This work demonstrates that visual practices can redistribute representational power by foregrounding everyday experience, embodied vulnerability, and situated knowledge that are often absent from institutional news coverage. Yet much of this scholarship remains oriented toward moments of heightened visibility—viral posts, spectacular imagery, or episodic mobilization—rather than toward the cumulative, everyday processes through which meaning is sustained over time.

This study builds on these insights by examining Instagram as a site where visual practices function as forms of spatial and affective world-making. In the following paragraphs, we discuss the framework of countervisuality for digital placemaking that motivates our interpretation of everyday Palestinian discourse as symbolic geographies. Our approach emphasizes how meaning emerges through repetition, circulation, and shared cultural reference.

Countervisuality for digital placemaking

In contexts where physical geographies and historical narratives are actively contested, visual practices play a central role in shaping how space, memory, and political belonging are understood. Countervisuality, as theorized by Mirzoeff (2011), refers to the production of alternative ways of seeing that challenge dominant regimes of perception and knowledge. Rather

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than merely opposing dominant images, countervisual practices reorganize how visibility itself operates, rendering marginalized experiences intelligible within contested representational fields.

Within digital environments, countervisuality frequently takes the form of digital placemaking—spatial and affective practices through which individuals and communities assert presence, continuity, and belonging in the absence of territorial control (Gordon & de Souza e Silva, 2013; Wilken et al., 2020). Through hashtags, captions, geotags, and recurring visual motifs, users produce shared reference points that anchor memory and identity in place, even when physical access is denied. These practices generate what D'Ignazio and Klein (2020) describe as counterdata: forms of knowledge production that challenge dominant epistemic hierarchies by centering lived experience.

In the Palestinian context, such visual practices draw on long-standing traditions of cultural resistance, where storytelling, material culture, and aesthetic expression sustain political identity and historical continuity (Alareer, 2014; Khoury-Machool, 2007; Saad, 2019). Countervisual practices are challenged by platform governance and algorithmic moderation, which disproportionately suppress Arabic-language and pro-Palestinian content (Magdy et al., 2025; Jhaver et al., 2019). Visibility must therefore be continuously produced and defended through circulation, repetition, and collective participation. Large-scale projects such as Visualizing Palestine exemplify this through fact-checked infographics, yet everyday users also enact countervisuality. Through hashtags, geotags, and recurring visual motifs, users render homes, cities, and landscapes visible despite their physical erasure by repeatedly posting symbolic images—ruins, olive trees, embroidery, village names—that accrue resonance and resist invisibility (Andén-Papadopoulos, 2020).

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Countervisuality, therefore, offers a critical framework for interpreting images as a form of language—one that operates through *symbolic geographies* constituting visual syntax, affective resonance, and spatial reference rather than propositional discourse alone. Building on this framework, the following sections first examine how symbolic geographies are produced and sustained through digital practices (RQ1). Next, we analyze how Palestinian Instagram users construct countervisual representations of place in relation to dominant news narratives (RQ2). Finally, we examine how repetition functions as a mechanism of endurance and amplification within algorithmically governed environments (RQ3), shaping patterns of engagement and visibility over time.

Symbolic Geographies as a form of Countervisuality

Recent scholarship across media and communication studies has increasingly examined how digital platforms shape spatial imaginaries, political belonging, and collective memory. Within this literature, symbolic geographies have emerged as a useful lens for understanding how representations of space—particularly in contexts of conflict and displacement—are mobilized to produce meaning, identity, and claims to belonging. We conceptualize symbolic geographics as the memory-laden, emotionally charged representations of place, produced under displacement and surveillance, where space and belonging are asserted through visual storytelling and textual claims that reclaim presence. Unlike cartographic maps, which abstract space through scale and control, symbolic geographies are *affective mappings* constructed through recurring motifs, spatial references, captioning conventions, and aesthetic framing. On platforms such as Instagram, these practices function as a *multimodal communicative system* with compositional "syntax" (framing, sequencing, repetition) and symbolic "semantics" (culturally resonant cues) that together enable users to memorialize what has been destroyed, document what persists, and reclaim visibility over

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contested spatial narratives. This recognition motivates our turn to symbolic geographies as a framework for analyzing how dispersed acts of visual narration collectively map conflictual spaces through memory, emotion, and repetition.

This conceptualization builds on a longer lineage of scholarship that treats space as constructed through systems of representation. Said's (1978) notion of imaginative geographies shows how discursive formations delineate who belongs where, while Gregory (1994) demonstrates how such imaginaries structure geopolitical power by organizing visibility, legitimacy, and violence. These dynamics intensify on digital platforms, where images circulate rapidly, networkedly, and affectively.

Symbolic geographies also intersect with scholarship on countervisuality. Mirzoeff (2011) argues that marginalized groups resist dominant regimes of seeing by producing alternative visual knowledge. In our context, symbolic geographies expand this insight by showing how users do not only refuse dominant imagery but also rebuild place through vernacular motifs, repetition, and embodied spatial cues.

Work on digital placemaking similarly highlights how online practices embed physical locations within networks of memory, emotion, and social relation. Images of homes, landscapes, and cultural objects do not merely represent place but sustain it, operating as infrastructures of continuity that maintain ties to homeland through iterative visual cues and culturally meaningful motifs. Symbolic geographies bring these strands of research together while extending them in important ways. Rather than treating images solely as vehicles of affect, protest, or visibility, symbolic geographies conceptualize visual practices as spatially generative: they produce place through memory, narrative, and repetition. In this sense, symbolic geographies anchor shared

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emotion in lived geographies and historical continuity, shifting collective identification from episodic moments of outrage toward enduring forms of belonging. They also extend countervisuality by foregrounding the reconstruction of place as a resistance to dominant imagery and against regimes of erasure.

In Palestine, where territorial control and historical narration are continually contested, these visual practices take on heightened political significance. Symbolic geographies function as assertions of vitality, continuity, and endurance—what Ftouni (2024) describes as affirmations of life. Images foregrounding everyday routines, domestic intimacy, or aesthetic continuity operate as political claims to survivance in contexts of extreme violence (Butler, 2016). Moreover, the layering of image and text, repetition of vernacular motifs, and evocation of familiar landscapes construct meanings that are legible within shared cultural frameworks while remaining resilient to algorithmic suppression or geopolitical erasure. Such practices contribute to what Shehadeh (2023) describes as a "floating homeland," sustained through memory, circulation, and shared visual repertoires rather than territorial sovereignty. Yet, despite expanding research on digital placemaking, counterpublics, and visual activism, less attention has been paid to how such practices cohere into broader communicative systems that organize meaning over time. The framework of symbolic geographies moves us beyond cataloguing individual images to examining how recurring motifs and patterned representations crystallize into interconnected systems of meaning. Through this lens, we ask:

RQ1: Which are the themes in Palestinians' Instagram posts that contribute to a representation of Palestine?

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Our work reconceptualizes symbolic geographies as a communicative phenomenon, beyond cataloguing storytelling motifs, toward identifying the broader organizing logics that give them coherence. Such higher-order patterns can reveal how everyday posts work in concert to assert presence, embed political meaning, and sustain collective memory in volatile media environments.

Examining the evidence for countervisuality

While symbolic geographies on Instagram emerge through everyday acts of digital placemaking, their political significance becomes most visible when contrasted with dominant media representations of Palestine. Mainstream news coverage of the 2023–2025 Gaza genocide has largely framed events through lenses of crisis, security, and exceptional violence, privileging military perspectives and official state narratives (Cherkaoui, 2024; Khamis & Dogbatse, 2024). A growing body of scholarship demonstrates that Western media outlets—including the BBC, CNN, *The New York Times*, and *The Guardian*—systematically frame Israeli military actions as defensive or necessary, while Palestinian actions are framed through tropes of terrorism or disorder (Heni et al., 2022; Elmasry, 2024; Butt et al., 2023).

Recent systematic analyses further show that such framing is neither incidental nor neutral. Ehsham, Jabar, and Yunus (2025) demonstrate that mainstream media coverage consistently reproduces narrative asymmetries that legitimize Israeli state violence while marginalizing Palestinian perspectives, reinforcing what they describe as a structural bias embedded in journalistic routines and geopolitical alignments. This narrative architecture normalizes occupation and obscures the historical conditions that produce violence in the first place. As Alioglu (2025) argues, these representational practices function as a form of digital

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occupation, relying on emotional framing, selective visibility, and moral asymmetry to justify violence while rendering Palestinian suffering abstract or exceptional. Chronological distortions – where coverage begins with Palestinian retaliation rather than structural violence – further erase the longue durée of occupation and dispossession. In this way, mainstream media naturalize power, fix identities, and delimit whose suffering is legible.

Against this backdrop, user-generated content on Instagram operates as a form of countervisuality that reorients how Palestinian space and life are seen. Prior research shows that social media posts often sustain affective continuity through images of homes, streets, rituals, and landscape markers that anchor place to memory, identity, and cultural endurance (Andén-Papadopoulos, 2020; Sa'di & Abu-Lughod, 2007). Building on this work, we expect that user-generated Instagram content foregrounds quotidian experiences that rarely appear in institutional news narratives. Images of balconies, markets, family gatherings, and familiar streets situate Palestinian cities within lived social worlds rather than exceptionalized zones of violence, asserting presence where erasure is normalized.

This contrast reveals that countervisuality operates not merely through oppositional imagery, but through alternative representational logics. Whereas mainstream media often compress space into event-driven spectacles shaped by geopolitical framing (Gregory, 2004), Instagram posts re-expand space through repetition, intimacy, and affective density. In doing so, they function as a vernacular archive—a decentralized, affect-rich form of counterdata (D'Ignazio & Klein, 2020)—that documents everyday life under conditions of siege while resisting the epistemic constraints of dominant media narratives.

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Prior scholarship has shown how Palestinian users employ mnemonic and symbolic practices—naming pre-1948 villages, documenting domestic rituals, circulating recurring visual motifs—to reassert continuity and presence (Kadman, 2015; Agha, 2020). We build on this work by conceptualizing such practices as countervisual strategies that directly contest hegemonic modes of seeing and knowing. Through repetition, affect, and spatial reference, these posts challenge dominant frames that depict Palestinian life as transient, exceptional, or disposable. Accordingly, we examine how countervisual practices on Instagram function in relation to mainstream news coverage, asking:

RQ2. In what ways do Palestinians' Instagram posts about key cities function as acts of countervisuality when compared to press coverage?

Our analysis focuses on five cities—Gaza, Jerusalem, Bethlehem, Nablus, and Ramallah—to consider how digital placemaking, visual repetition, and counterdata practices compare with dominant media framings in the news headlines of prominent news outlets.

Repetition as visual strategy

In algorithmically governed environments, where visibility is contingent on engagement metrics and moderation practices are uneven, repetition functions as a key mechanism through which countervisual narratives gain durability. Prior research on online movements suggests that collective meaning is not sustained through expression alone, but through circulation and reinforcement across networks. In this sense, repetition operates as an infrastructural condition of political visibility: it enables visual content to persist, accumulate recognition, and remain legible within platform architectures shaped by algorithmic sorting and governance. This dynamic is especially consequential in contexts where digital expression is structurally precarious.

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Building on this insight, our analysis extends prior conceptualizations of repetition as the duplication of content (Jaidka, 2025) to also consider the patterned rearticulation of shared themes, symbols, and visual logics across posts and users. Shared vocabularies emerge through the repeated production, circulation, and reinterpretation of images (Siapera, 2014; Couldry, 2008), while networked visuals accrue meaning through iterative interaction rather than isolated publication (Rubinstein & Sluis, 2008). In this sense, symbolic geographies take shape through patterned circulation: meaning emerges not from sameness, but from resonance across related visual expressions over time.

Crucially, engagement plays an active role in this process. When images circulate widely and generate affective responses—likes, comments, reposts—they signal that meaning is being collectively recognized and negotiated. Engagement thus functions as a mechanism through which visibility and affect reinforce one another: emotional resonance increases circulation, while circulation stabilizes meaning. Rather than serving merely as metrics of popularity, engagement indicators operate as traces of collective sense-making, revealing which symbolic forms succeed in mobilizing attention, identification, and shared interpretation.

This dynamic is especially evident in the Palestinian context, where Arabic-language and pro-Palestinian content is disproportionately flagged, suppressed, or removed through opaque moderation systems (Magdy et al., 2025; Jhaver et al., 2019). Under such conditions, repetition becomes a strategy for countering erasure by sustaining visibility across time and platforms. Recurrent visual motifs—keys, rubble, balconies, domestic interiors—generate visual density and shared interpretive frameworks that allow meaning to persist despite systemic constraint. Through repeated posting and aesthetic alignment, these motifs sustain emotional presence,

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collective identification, and mnemonic continuity across dispersed digital encounters (Andén-Papadopoulos, 2020).

While existing scholarship on visual resistance has focused primarily on symbolic representation, less attention has been paid to how repetition structures interaction, visibility, and endurance within platformed environments (Bayramoğlu, 2023). Attending to repetition as a mechanism of reinforcement clarifies how countervisual practices persist and scale despite algorithmic constraint (Jaidka, 2025). Engagement, in this sense, is not an endpoint but a process through which meaning circulates, stabilizes, and becomes collectively legible. This leads to our third research question:

RQ3. How does the repetition of countervisual themes in Palestinian Instagram posts relate to patterns of user engagement (e.g., likes and comments)?

Method

This study adopts a multi-method research design that integrates qualitative thematic analysis with quantitative engagement metrics to examine how Palestinian Instagram users employ multimodal language—visual and textual—to post about Palestinian places during a six-month period in 2023-2024. The combination of qualitative and quantitative techniques enables us to capture both the expressive richness of digital placemaking and the platform dynamics that shape its visibility and circulation. Below, we detail the procedures for identifying accounts, collecting data, sampling posts, developing the codebook, and conducting annotation and analysis.

Participant Sampling and Data Collection

We drew on a purposive sample of Palestinian Instagram users who participated in a widely circulated story-based campaign initiated by @hareth_palestine in June 2024. The campaign

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invited users to repost a template and add the name of their family's town in Palestine. This moment of mass participation functioned as a collectively performed act of digital placemaking.

From public responses to the campaign, we manually compiled 834 unique Palestinian Instagram accounts. These accounts were selected because they explicitly engaged in symbolic representations of place, offering insight into how individuals mobilize personal images, narrative cues, and cultural symbols to signal attachment to homeland.

We collected all public feed posts (excluding stories) published by these accounts from October 8, 2023 to March 31, 2024, using Meta's public insights platform CrowdTangle. For each post, we retrieved the visual media, caption, hashtags, timestamp, and engagement metrics (likes, comments; shares only when available). Non-English captions were first translated into English for consistency using the M2M-100 multilingual translation model (Fan et al., 2021), a many-to-many neural machine translation system trained on parallel data covering 100 languages. The model has demonstrated substantial improvements over prior multilingual translation methods and has the added advantage of being deployable entirely **locally**, as an open-source library, without transmitting or storing user data on external servers. This allowed us to translate captions securely without relying on cloud-based services or platform-mediated processing.

Location-Based Filtering

Because our research examines *symbolic geographies*, we restricted the dataset to posts that referenced specific Palestinian locations. This procedure unfolded in two steps.

- Hashtag filtering: We extracted every hashtag from the dataset and generated frequency tables in R. Using pattern-matching functions (e.g., grep), we filtered for hashtags containing geographic terms. We then manually curated this list to ensure that only

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towns, cities, and regions within Palestine (e.g., Gaza, Jenin, Nablus, Deir al-Balah) were retained. Ambiguous or politically sensitive terms were cross-verified by the research team.

- Caption-Level Toponym Extraction: To supplement hashtag filtering, we processed caption text using the Python package geotext to identify toponyms, which we matched against the verified list of Palestinian locations. This step identified additional geographically relevant posts even when users did not use explicit location hashtags.

Posts that did not reference Palestinian places in either hashtags or captions were excluded. The final dataset included 9,126 posts.

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Codebook Development

We developed the thematic codebook through an iterative, inductive process designed to capture both the visual and textual elements that structure user-generated posts.

Exploratory analysis

The coding framework emerged from a series of exploratory engagements with the data, beginning with an initial review of 50 randomly selected posts drawn from the full dataset. During this preliminary stage, two trained coders independently examined the posts to identify recurring patterns in image composition, motif use, and thematic content. This early review helped establish an initial distinction between types of visual materials—such as photographs, infographics, animations, illustrations, and screenshots—as well as a set of provisional thematic categories that frequently appeared across the sample.

Because the posts varied markedly in their mode of production and expressive function, we treated image type as a meaningful analytic feature. For instance, distinguishing between photographs and designed materials allowed us to discern how users alternated between documenting lived experiences and intentionally crafting symbolic messages. Parallel to this, we began formulating thematic categories that captured the substantive concerns depicted within the posts. Some themes, such as Destruction or Healthcare, were grounded in direct visual cues, while others—such as Displacement, Everyday Life, or Resilience—required interpretive engagement with both images and captions. These distinctions emerged naturally from the coders' early annotations and guided the subsequent refinement of the codebook.

Pilot annotation

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To build a shared interpretive understanding, the coders next conducted a trial coding exercise using a separate set of 60 posts. Each coder annotated all posts independently and recorded the image type, proposed theme, and a brief justification describing the salient features that informed their decision. These notes served as the basis for a collaborative review meeting in which coders compared interpretations and discussed areas of divergence. Through this process, the initial list of broad thematic categories was refined into a more precise and analytically useful set. For example, the early category of "Violence" was expanded into the more specific themes of "Destruction," referring to damage to buildings and infrastructure, and "Displacement," referring to violence enacted on people and the conditions forcing them from their homes. Similarly, new categories such as "Care/Kindness" and "Protest/Call for Justice" were added to capture recurrent motifs that were not fully represented in the preliminary list.

Rather than calculating a statistical measure of intercoder reliability—a practice not well suited for inductive qualitative analysis—we relied on an iterative consensus-building approach in which the coders jointly refined definitions, clarified theme boundaries, and aligned interpretations. This approach ensured that both coders worked from a shared conceptual framework and that the codebook was grounded in a coherent analytic logic rather than a rigid pre-structured taxonomy.

By the end of the pilot annotation, we had developed a finalized codebook containing eleven thematic categories and seven image types. Each category included a definition, inclusion and exclusion criteria, and example cases that articulated how coders should apply the theme across diverse multimodal contexts. This finalized codebook served as the foundation for annotating the main sample of posts and is reproduced in full in the Supplemental Material (Tables S3–S5).

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Main Annotation Procedure

The final codebook comprises two levels of annotation:

- Level 1 identified themes based on direct visual cues (e.g., Death, Destruction, Healthcare)
- Level 2 captured interpretive themes requiring contextual information from captions or hashtags (e.g., Displacement, Everyday Life, Resilience).

The finalized codebook was applied to a random sample of 500 posts, representing approximately 5.5% of the full dataset (N = 9,126). The same two coders who had developed the codebook conducted all annotations to ensure continuity in interpretive perspective. Each post was coded at the post level for both its image type and its single most dominant theme. Coders drew on the codebook's rules of thematic salience to guide their decisions, especially in cases where visual and textual cues pointed to different interpretive possibilities. These rules helped determine whether a theme was dominant based on visual centrality, recurrence of motifs, or the strength of textual framing.

Throughout the annotation process, the coders held regular check-ins to discuss ambiguous or challenging cases, aligning their interpretations and maintaining the shared analytic framework established during codebook development. This iterative, consultative approach is consistent with qualitative standards that prioritize depth of interpretive agreement over statistical measures of intercoder reliability.

Once the thematic annotation was complete, we conducted a deeper qualitative analysis of posts within each major category. This interpretive phase examined how symbolic geographies were constructed across modalities, paying attention to recurring visual motifs,

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spatial cues, compositional strategies, and the linguistic work performed in captions and hashtags. This stage enabled us to move beyond identifying *what* the posts depict to understanding *how* users craft meaning through multimodal storytelling. It provided insight into the psychosocial functions of these posts, including how they signal resilience, preserve memory, document harm, or assert spatial belonging in a context marked by displacement, violence, and loss.

Data Analysis Procedure

Comparison of user and press themes

As a next step, we investigated whether user-generated Instagram posts function as acts of countervisuality by challenging the dominant representations prevalent in mainstream news media. To this end, we employed a comparative visual discourse framework focused on five cities most frequently featured in the Instagram corpus: Gaza, Jerusalem, Bethlehem, Nablus, and Ramallah. From our annotated dataset, we filtered down to 172 posts that explicitly referenced these cities, either through geotags, captions, or hashtags.

To construct a comparative baseline, we compiled a press corpus of 7,449 news articles published in March 2024 using NewsAPI.org. This dataset included coverage from major international outlets such as The Washington Post, New York Times, Al Jazeera, and others, providing a diverse yet representative sample of mainstream media narratives about the same five Palestinian cities. We classified the headlines of these news articles using ChatGPT 4-o- based annotation, applying the same thematic codebook used for Instagram posts. Because our headline corpus consists of publicly available news texts with no personal or sensitive information, the use of large language models for annotation posed no privacy risks and offered a reliable,

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scalable alternative to manual coding. Furthermore, recent work in communication and computational social science shows that large language models can achieve validity and reliability comparable to trained human annotators, particularly for subjective or interpretive media corpora such as news articles and social-media posts (Törnberg, 2025). To ensure accuracy, we manually inspected the LLM-generated classifications against a randomly selected subset of 100 headlines, and identified no mismatches between the model's labels and our own judgements. Validation results are reported in Table S9 in the Supplemental Material.

We then conducted a thematic comparison of the news headlines and Instagram posts to assess the extent to which user-generated content offered alternative framings, symbolic references, or visual motifs that resist or reframe dominant portrayals. To test whether the distribution of themes differed significantly between news headlines and Instagram posts, we conducted a chi-square test of independence. We constructed a contingency table using theme frequencies for each source with a minimum of ten observations and computed the test statistic using the expected counts under the null hypothesis of independence.

Engagement metrics and thematic repetition

To examine the relationship between specific countervisual themes and user engagement on Instagram, we focused on five prominent thematic categories identified in the user-generated dataset: *Political Mobilization*, *Solidarity and Community*, *Everyday Life*, *Knowledge Cultivation*, and *Resilience*. These themes were selected based on both their frequency and their conceptual alignment with recurring visual motifs commonly used in countervisual storytelling.

Engagement was measured using a composite interaction score that combined likes and comments. View counts were excluded due to inconsistent availability across posts. We also

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incorporated Instagram's platform-generated "Overperforming Score," which evaluates post performance relative to each account's baseline, offering a normalized measure of visibility and engagement. To assess the association between thematic content and engagement, we divided posts into terciles based on their overperforming scores (low, medium, high engagement). We then conducted chi-square tests of independence to compare the distribution of engagement levels for posts tagged with each theme against those without the theme, identifying whether certain themes were significantly associated with higher or lower engagement.

Results

This study identifies several thematic clusters through which Palestinian users construct a countervisual narrative that affirms identity, presence, and resistance. These themes reflect everyday experiences, collective memory, resilience, and calls for justice, foregrounding emotional and symbolic strategies to resist erasure and domination. The full list of themes and their characteristics is provided in Table 1. Table 1 also exemplifies these themes through posts from the dataset. Together, the thematic and visual classifications provide a framework for analyzing how Palestinian Instagram users mobilize imagery in the service of cultural and political resistance.

Content characteristics

Classifying the content of the 500 annotated Instagram posts yielded eleven key themes: political mobilization, solidarity and community, everyday life, knowledge-cultivation, resilience, death, violence (destruction and displacement), play, kindness, and healthcare. While these themes varied in frequency, **political mobilization** (33.6%) and **everyday life** (24.8%) were the most prevalent, together accounting for more than half of the dataset. These two categories—one

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overtly political, the other rooted in ordinary and symbolic acts of presence—highlight the dual logic of Palestinian visual storytelling: advocating for justice while asserting lived experience.

Over a third of the dataset focuses on **political mobilization (33.6%)** and **solidarity (10.8%)** through messages of protest, boycott, and demands for justice that function as digital sites of collective action and resistance. Users document both physical demonstrations and online advocacy, employing direct political language that challenges platform censorship. The solidarity theme captures posts showing emotional and political support for Palestinians across borders. Users use countervisual tactics to navigate social media censorship and emotional fatigue. Rather than overt imagery of violence, many posts center community and solidarity to mobilize public awareness and collective action.

In the following paragraphs, we will discuss the themes that contribute to the digital placemaking strategies of Palestinian Instagram users, while the full set of themes is reported and discussed in Table 1.

Content symbols and motifs

We documented recurring visual motifs that cut across categories and served as symbolic anchors of Palestinian countervisuality. The first set of motifs pertains to the calls for mobilization and solidarity through the use of *symbolic visualization as resistance*. The strategic deployment of recognizable symbols—Palestinian flags, keffiyeh patterns, watermelon imagery, barbed wire motifs, and return keys—creates visual coherence across fragmented digital spaces. These symbols, coupled with widely shared phrases like “I stand with Palestine” created a shared emotional language of support and belonging in digital space. In contexts where Palestinian

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political expression faces suppression, these symbolic elements function as a form of visual shorthand for broader narratives.

The second set of motifs pertains to elements of visual storytelling. These motifs include rubble, press vests, the sea, children, injured bodies, medical supplies, and Palestinian flags. Images of rubble and building ruins frequently appear as backdrops for other actions: play when juxtaposed with scenes of football or parkour; prayer with text or symbols of religion; protest, when foregrounded with the Palestinian flag, and caregiving when seen with medical or food supplies. The presence of press reporters, often captured in the act of documenting or being documented, highlights the blurred boundary between witnessing and resistance. Children, whether injured, playing, or smiling, recur as symbols of resilience and loss.

By consistently circulating these specific visual markers alongside captions that directly critique occupation policies or promote solidarity actions, users establish a recognizable visual vocabulary that transcends individual posts. These symbols become anchors for digital placemaking, transforming scattered protest documentation into a cohesive visual movement that resists dominant narratives attempting to isolate or delegitimize Palestinian collective action. The repetition of such visual elements across user posts forms a shared visual vocabulary (Shiffman, 2013) —one that reinforces themes of endurance, injustice, and communal identity under occupation.

Table 1: Themes and examples from the dataset. *Note: links to the original posts are included for the peer review but will be redacted on publication to protect users' privacy.*

Theme	Definition	Visual Indicators	Example Description	Instructions to coders	Sample Image

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Political mobilization (33.6%)	Images showing collective gatherings or actions expressing dissent, demand for change, or social activism.	Crowds with protest signs, banners, raised fists, confrontations with authorities, large gatherings	An image of a large crowd holding signs and banners, with raised fists or vocal expressions of protest.	Identify clear symbols of collective dissent, not general gatherings.	https://www.instagram.com/p/CzKdUlDIVU1/
	Images that reflect calls to action for boycotting, often showing protest signs, specific product symbols, or slogans.	Slogans, banners, or symbols associated with boycott movements, specific brands or products targeted.	A banner showing 'Boycott' with a product image, or protest signs against certain brands.	Focus on clear visual indicators that promote or imply boycotting.	https://www.instagram.com/p/C0o-6MmRrGP/
	Images that depict or imply the pursuit of fairness, resistance, or advocacy for human rights, often in the context of protests, solidarity, or legal symbolism.	Protest marches with flags, people holding signs advocating for freedom or justice, demonstrations with Palestinian flags, or symbolic acts of resistance	Depictions of protests, solidarity movements, or artistic expressions calling for accountability and fairness	Focus on images that highlight symbolic acts of resistance or advocacy for accountability	https://www.instagram.com/p/CdegNGNt3x4/
Solidarity and Community (10.8%)	Images reflecting collective support, unity, or solidarity, especially in challenging times.	Crowds gathered in unity, people embracing, helping each other, or holding banners symbolizing unity.	A crowd holding hands, or community members holding banners together in solidarity.	Focus on gestures or actions that show community bonds and support.	https://www.instagram.com/p/C0pM5uJrXxz/
	Images that depict acts of solidarity, mutual aid, or collective care, emphasizing the strength of the community	People distributing food or water, neighbours rebuilding homes together, collective efforts in aiding the injured	Volunteers providing meals to displaced families	Focus on visuals that emphasize communal strength and support, particularly in the context of addressing the aftermath of violence or displacement	https://www.instagram.com/p/C5oKlt8sMKX/
Everyday life (24.8%)	Images capturing scenes of daily life, including common activities, routines, or leisure moments in Palestinian settings. Everyday life, before/ after genocide (typical day in Gaza)	People preparing food, shopping, socializing, participating in cultural or family traditions.	Families enjoying a meal, people shopping at a local market, children playing in a safe area.	Differentiate from more dramatic or symbolic scenes by focusing on routine activities.	https://www.instagram.com/p/B7dEDDCgAHw/
Knowledge cultivation (11.4%)	Images sharing information, facts, or statistics, often through infographics, signs, or text overlays.	Text overlays with statistics, infographics, or signs with educational content.	A graphic showing statistics on an issue, or a sign with educational text.	Differentiate from protest or boycott by focusing on the intent to inform.	https://www.instagram.com/p/CydnFrLMarZ/
Resilience (8.8%)	Images showing individuals or communities persevering, demonstrating gratitude, hope, or positive emotions amidst hardship.	Smiling faces, individuals showing determination, people engaging in daily life with signs of gratitude or positivity.	A person smiling while surrounded by destruction, or people gathering for a meal with expressions of gratitude.	Focus on positive expressions or gestures despite challenging circumstances.	https://www.instagram.com/p/C7XKm8MuSmZ/

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Death (3.2%)	Images that depict or imply the loss of life, including scenes of deceased bodies, funerals, mourning, or visual cues suggesting death.	Deceased bodies, covered bodies, people in mourning, coffins, traditional symbols of death (e.g., flowers, candles)	A photo showing mourners gathered around a coffin, or an image of bodies covered in blankets.	Focus on visuals that explicitly suggest death, not just injury or medical aid.	https://www.instagram.com/p/C7lZo3htNd7/
Destruction (2.8%)	Images focusing on the physical destruction of property, infrastructure, or natural landscapes as a result of conflict.	Rubble, damaged buildings, broken infrastructure, landscapes altered by damage.	Scenes of bombed buildings, rubble in residential areas, or damaged streets.	Differentiate from other themes by focusing on physical damage rather than human activity.	https://www.instagram.com/p/C6TunN1rwsP/
Play (2.2%)	Images that depict scenes of leisure, recreation, or entertainment, including activities involving children, sports, or communal games.	Children playing with makeshift toys, youth participating in simple games	A group of children kicking soccer ball etc.	Focus on visuals of play as acts of resilience and normalcy	https://www.instagram.com/p/CZho9VpL1j4/
Displacement (1.4%)	Images depicting people displaced from their homes, living in temporary shelters, or visibly on the move.	Refugee camps, tents, people carrying belongings, groups relocating.	A family in a makeshift shelter or people gathered with packed belongings in an open area.	Focus on visuals that imply relocation or temporary living situations.	https://www.instagram.com/p/Cz7VsvnIMg9/
Kindness (0.8%)	Images depicting acts of kindness, generosity, or care towards others, including humans and animals.	Sharing food, giving aid, patting or caring for animals, helping others visibly in need.	A person sharing food with others, or someone gently caring for a stray animal.	Focus on acts that visibly show compassion or care.	https://www.instagram.com/p/C5oKlt8sMKX/
Healthcare (0.2%)	Images depicting healthcare services or medical care, including scenes of hospital beds, medical facilities, healthcare workers, and patients receiving care.	Hospital beds, medical facilities, healthcare workers in uniforms, patients in care, medical equipment like IV drips or monitors.	A hospital room with patients on beds, healthcare workers attending to them, or medical equipment in use.	Focus on visuals related to healthcare provision or facilities, not just general injury or distress.	https://www.instagram.com/p/C8AEmA9tuDd/

Themes for digital placemaking

Everyday life (24.8%)

This theme comprises posts documenting ordinary aspects of Palestinian life. Family portraits appear most frequently, followed by landscapes, architecture, and cultural objects. About half of all of these seemingly mundane images are paired with text explicitly referencing occupation, displacement, or restrictions. Possessive determiners appear prominently, with “my” and “our”

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preceding place names, creating direct relationships between users and locations like Jerusalem and specific villages. Visual subject matter often appears innocuous—sunsets comprise many images in this category, while discarded objects appear often, yet captions frequently recontextualize these visuals. For example, a post showing only a sunset explains that "sunsets in the winter are the warning that they are going to be under complete darkness while they have no electricity." Hashtags function as geographic anchors, with #ramallah, #jerusalem, and #gaza frequently appearing alongside seemingly apolitical images, creating and reclaiming documented connections between users and specific places that might otherwise be omitted from digital representations.

In summary, the countervisual strategies of particular significance in the Everyday life theme were the *use of possessive determiners* as resistance and *visual evasion* strategies. First, by claiming spaces through possessive markers— "my," "our"—users visually reclaim place and assert belonging. Second, many employ coded visual tactics that pair innocuous images (sunsets, discarded objects) with captions alluding to occupation, power outages, or displaced memories. This deliberate ambiguity helps circumvent content moderation while embedding political meaning in seemingly ordinary visuals. When Palestinian spaces are frequently omitted from cartographic platforms, these combined strategies of possessive naming and visual evasion appear intentional at resisting erasure and subverting algorithmic moderation.

Knowledge cultivation (11.4%)

This theme comprises posts that share factual information and cultural knowledge. Geographical naming appears frequently, with over a third of the posts in this category specifically naming Palestinian villages (e.g., "Ein Al Rayhana") alongside their histories. Historical content

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constitutes a substantive proportion of these posts, often documenting pre-1967 land conditions, as illustrated in one caption describing a spring that "was once a flourishing farm but things changed with the occupation in 1967." Political figures appear in many posts, with Yasser Arafat mentioned most frequently, typically accompanied by biographical details such as "he devoted his life for the Palestinian cause." Traditional Palestinian practices also feature in these posts, including visual documentation of olive oil extraction, embroidery techniques, and food preparation alongside intergenerational knowledge transfer, often showing elders teaching younger generations. Environmental changes are also documented, with mentions of introduced species ("the occupation released the wild pigs which aren't native to this land") and agricultural challenges. Posts frequently combine educational content with personal connection, as seen in captions referring to "my village" when describing historical sites, creating documented relationships between current users and specific geographical locations through a reinforced sharing of cultural knowledge.

Overall, we observed that under the Knowledge cultivation theme, a particularly important strategy was *the use of historical documentation* as resistance. The detailed naming and description of places, historical figures, and traditional practices functions as a form of epistemic counternarrative in a digital archive that reconstruct territorial relationships and cultural continuity. Users assert historical presence that challenges settler colonial temporalities by anchoring specific geographical features to their Arabic names, documenting environmental changes since occupation, or preserving cultural techniques through visual documentation. These knowledge-sharing practices transform social media from mere communication channels into sites of collective memory formation, where detailed accounts of land use, political leadership,

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and everyday cultural practices maintain connections to places increasingly threatened with physical and narrative displacement.

Resilience (8.8%)

This theme encompasses posts displaying emotional endurance and hope amid conflict. Posts in this category frequently feature images of smiling individuals, family celebrations, and children's artwork. Captions often pair these positive visuals with explicit acknowledgments of struggle, as seen in a birthday post where the author writes: “Happy Birthday, pops. I'm so sorry it's during the saddest and most depressing of times.” Religious references appear in about a third of posts in this category, with common phrases including “Allahu Akbar” (God is most great) and hashtags like #PalestineWillBeFree. Children feature prominently as subjects, with many posts depicting or discussing children's experiences, such as through drawings of destroyed houses. Many posts document personal milestones alongside references to displacement, frequently mentioning symbolic keys of return and ancestral homes.

Of particular importance within the resilience theme is the use of *affective visualization* as resistance and *humanizing narrative* strategies. By presenting images of smiling faces, family celebrations, and children's artwork, users visually reclaim agency and emotional complexity beyond victimhood narratives. They may reappropriate images of death, violence or destruction, to portray beauty in ruin, smiles amidst grief, and joy in dispossession, thereby mobilizing emotional and cultural registers that destabilize dominant portrayals of Palestinians as either passive victims or violent actors. These images can reframe the Palestinian subject as resilient, loving, grieving, rooted, and defiant. Furthermore, this deliberate pairing of joy with acknowledgment of struggle appears intentional to humanize the Palestinian presence,

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challenging decontextualized media portrayals. In contexts where Palestinian emotional lives are frequently flattened or overlooked, these combined strategies of affective visualization and humanizing narratives function as forms of digital place-making that resist erasure through the assertion of full emotional citizenship. Yet, these visual strategies do more than humanize in a descriptive sense; they perform what Ftouni (2024) conceptualizes as an affirmation of life under conditions of structural death. By foregrounding scenes of care, joy, and continuity—often in proximity to destruction—users do not merely counter narratives of victimhood but articulate an alternative ontology of life that persists despite violence. This challenges dominant humanitarian frames that recognize Palestinians primarily through suffering or innocence (Butler, 2016; Ticktin, 2017). Rather than seeking recognition through victimhood alone, these images insist on the fullness of Palestinian life—its attachments, pleasures, and futures—thereby contesting the colonial allocation of whose lives count as grievable or politically legible. In this sense, everyday imagery operates as a form of life-affirming resistance, asserting presence not through spectacle, but through continuity.

For a detailed overview of all thematic categories, including examples of strategies and representative posts for digital placemaking, please refer to Table S6 in the Supplemental Material.

Comparison of user and press themes

Table 2 compares the distribution of thematic content in mainstream news headlines (N = 7,448) and the set of annotated Instagram posts (N = 172) that explicitly reference Gaza, Jerusalem, Bethlehem, Nablus, or Ramallah. News headlines were annotated using large language models

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using the themes identified and annotated in the Instagram posts (as described previously), to offer a comparison against the manually annotated Instagram posts.

The chi-square test of independence confirmed a statistically significant difference in thematic distributions between the news headlines and Instagram posts ($\chi^2(8, N=2)=104.95$, $p<.001$). This result suggests that the two sources emphasize different narrative themes. News coverage was dominated by themes such as Knowledge Cultivation (48.36%) and Death (14.65%), with a relatively limited focus on themes like Resilience (0.29%) or Solidarity and Community (0.15%). In contrast, Instagram posts exhibited markedly different patterns, with high frequencies for Political Mobilization (39.53%), Everyday Life (19.19%), and Resilience (11.63%). These results reinforce our argument that Instagram posts function as counterdata: users' Instagram content diverges from mainstream media in its thematic focus and actively foregrounds lived experiences and emotional continuity over abstracted reporting.

Table 2. Thematic comparison of news headlines and Instagram posts referencing five key Palestinian cities

Themes	**Instagram posts (N = 172)**	**News headlines (N = 7,448)**
Political mobilization	39.53% (68)	3.52% (262)
Everyday	19.19% (33)	1.21% (90)
Resilience	11.63% (20)	0.29% (22)
Knowledge cultivation	8.14% (14)	48.36% (3602)
Solidarity & Community	6.98% (12)	0.15% (11)
Death	5.81% (10)	14.65% (1091)
Destruction	5.81% (10)	11.92% (888)
Healthcare	2.32% (4)	9.39% (700)
Displacement	1.74% (3)	6.67% (497)

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User engagement with digital placemaking strategies

Table 3 summarizes the engagement on the five major content themes from the dataset. Table 4 reveals statistically significant associations between **user engagement** and the themes of **Political Mobilization** and **Everyday life** content.

Protest-themed posts had a disproportionately higher frequency in the medium engagement group, suggesting that this category effectively maintains visibility but may not always provoke the most substantial interaction. Everyday life posts, on the other hand, were more evenly distributed across engagement levels. Still, their statistical significance suggests that ordinary content, when repeated, can play a key role in sustaining presence and resonance under conditions of algorithmic volatility.

While Knowledge cultivation posts showed a marginal association with engagement, Resilience and Solidarity themes did not show significant variation in engagement. These findings indicate that repetition (the number of themed posts) alone does not guarantee engagement. Instead, themes tied to politics (protest mobilization) and emotional familiarity (everyday life) appear more likely to resonate with audiences algorithmically and affectively.

These engagement patterns offer preliminary evidence that meaning-making on Instagram is shaped not only by what users express but by what gains traction under algorithmic sorting. The higher interaction rates for Everyday Life and Political Mobilization suggest that affective familiarity and explicit calls to action function as visibility-generating mechanisms. In this sense, engagement does not merely reflect audience interest but participates in determining

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which symbolic forms become more durable, more widely circulated, and more collectively legible within the platform.

Table 3: Engagement metrics on the five major content themes

Themes	Total likes	Total views	Total interactions	Count
Political mobilization	585291	65986	592176	168
Resilience	159844	2448	161222	44
Solidarity and Community	157081	16038	158361	54
Everyday	20047	56038	20981	124
Knowledge cultivation	12973	20072	13404	57

Table 4: Chisquare analysis of the relative engagement received by different content themes (* $p<0.05$)

Theme	Low	Medium	High	Chi-Square (χ^2)	df	p-value
Everyday Palestine	50	44	30	6.21	2	0.045*
Knowledge cultivation	21	18	18	5.55	2	0.062+
Resilience	10	24	10	2.71	2	0.258
Political mobilization	49	90	29	8.76	2	0.013*

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Solidarity and Community	19	24	11	0.13	2	0.936

Discussion

Our analysis reveals that symbolic geographies emerge from the interplay of linguistic and visual choices that make place, identity, and history visible in contested representational spaces. Individual posts participate in patterned communicative work—deploying spatial references, emotional framings, and culturally resonant motifs to produce shared understandings of Palestine. Strategic ambiguity in imagery, such as scenes of play or meals paired with captions referencing loss or displacement, enables users to convey politically charged messages while remaining within platform moderation boundaries. Temporal and geographic anchoring—through historic dates, seasonal rituals, or pre-1948 place names—transforms otherwise ephemeral content into a networked archive of memory. These patterned practices, when viewed through a language and social psychology lens, invite us to ask: what overarching communicative purposes do they serve, and how do linguistic and visual codes work together to achieve them? We address this question by examining three high-level goals that underpin the construction of symbolic geographies: claiming space, coding resistance, and collective remembering. Our engagement findings reinforce this point. Posts organized around everyday life, memory, and political mobilization consistently attracted higher interaction, indicating that affective resonance directly shapes which symbolic forms circulate and persist. Under algorithmic governance—where visibility is contingent on interaction and where pro-Palestinian content faces disproportionate suppression—engagement becomes part of the infrastructure through which countervisual meaning is stabilized. Likes, comments, and recirculation therefore act not only as indicators of audience

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response but as mechanisms of amplification, enabling symbolic geographies to endure despite platform volatility.

Claiming contested spaces through linguistic and visual claims

Our analysis shows that symbolic geographies are constructed through coordinated linguistic and visual strategies that assert belonging within contested spaces. Across the dataset, posts pair textual and visual markers to establish spatial attachment and political presence. Linguistically, possessive determiners ("our street," "my home," "our olive trees") and precise geographic references—village names, neighborhoods, historic landmarks—anchor posts in specific locations. Visually, these claims are reinforced through documentary images: family portraits, domestic interiors, or everyday scenes embedded in recognizable landscapes.

For example, posts depicting homes in neighborhoods such as Sheikh Jarrah or Silwan often pair intimate domestic imagery with captions asserting continuity ("this is our home," "we are still here"). In many cases, users geotag locations using pre-1948 village names or Arabic toponyms no longer recognized in official cartography, effectively reinscribing erased geographies into digital space. Images of children in doorways or elders seated in courtyards function not as nostalgic artifacts but as assertions of lived presence. Through these combined visual and linguistic cues, Instagram becomes a site of spatial claiming rather than mere documentation.

From a language and social psychology perspective, these practices work as multimodal acts of place-claiming. Textual elements function as verbal assertions of identity and ownership, while visual cues provide embodied, affective confirmation of those claims. Within social networks, symbols such as the keffiyeh, keys, olive trees, or images of home function operate as

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condensation symbols (Barthes, 1957; Graber, 1976; Kaufer & Carley, 1993; Kjeldsen, 2016): a material index of memory and return, that compress complex histories of displacement, resistance, and attachment into immediately legible visual shorthand. Through their repetition, many symbols, such as olive trees, do not merely represent place but also denote attachment to land, cultural traditions, and intergenerational memory. Together, they construct a digital geography that challenges the absence or distortion of Palestinian spaces in dominant cartographic and media representations.

The articulation of spatial belonging through these codes builds upon a long history of cultural resistance. Abu-Ayyash (2024) notes that Palestinian users deploy cultural symbols such as the thobe and keffiyeh to assert identity and national struggle online, linking representation to cultural continuity. In our data, these symbols appear as visual motifs—embroidered dresses, traditional headscarves—paired with location-specific hashtags that serve as persistent semiotic reminders of place. This strategy aligns with Said's (1993) argument that cultural narratives operate as counter-histories to imperial accounts, especially when grounded in physical and symbolic geographies. As Abu-Ayyash observes, "identity, culture, and national struggle are inseparable" in Palestinian representations online, with hashtags often functioning as embedded reminders to reinforce this interconnectedness. In Hall's (1997) terms, these practices form a system of representation in which visual and linguistic codes cohere to assert spatial presence in the contested communicative space of Instagram.

Coding resistance through strategic ambiguity

Beyond asserting presence, symbolic geographies also encode resistance through strategic ambiguity. Across content categories, users combine visually mundane or intimate scenes—

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children playing, shared meals, quiet domestic moments—with captions that carry politically charged or historically situated meanings. This multimodal layering enables content to operate on multiple interpretive levels: legible to in-group audiences while remaining sufficiently ambiguous to evade automated moderation.

For instance, images of everyday life are often paired with captions referencing displacement, siege, or historical loss, allowing political meaning to circulate without overt confrontation. Similarly, domestic objects such as keys, embroidery, or empty chairs function metonymically, standing in for displacement, interrupted futures, or inherited loss. These substitutions enable resistance to operate indirectly, embedding political meaning within everyday aesthetics rather than explicit slogans.

From a language and social psychology perspective, this ambiguity works by manipulating the pragmatic relationship between verbal and visual cues. The dissonance between what is seen and what is said invites selective decoding, allowing sympathetic audiences to access the intended political message while outsiders may register only a neutral scene. This aligns with Howarth's (2011) concept of "oppositional representations," which challenge dominant framings not through direct confrontation but via layered, alternative narratives. It also reflects Hall's (1997) notion of transcoding, whereby marginalized groups reclaim representational space by subverting dominant media expectations. Such strategies are particularly salient given the disproportionate moderation of Arabic and pro-Palestinian content (Alimardani & Elswah, 2021), making ambiguity a necessary condition for visibility. Strategic ambiguity allows political content to circulate by conforming to visual patterns that the platform interprets as "neutral" or "personal," thereby working with, rather than against, the algorithmic structures that govern visibility.

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Collective remembering as temporal anchors

Beyond spatial claims and coded resistance, symbolic geographies are sustained through practices of collective remembering. Across the dataset, users anchor present experiences to historical time by referencing pre-1967 landscapes, ancestral homes, anniversaries, and commemorative dates. These temporal markers transform ephemeral posts into a networked archive that asserts continuity despite displacement.

Temporal anchoring is especially visible in posts shared during anniversaries such as the Nakba, where contemporary images are juxtaposed with archival photographs or intergenerational narratives. Recurring hashtags tied to specific villages or historical moments link individual posts into broader mnemonic chains, allowing memory to accumulate through repetition rather than singular documentation. In this way, repetition functions not merely as visual redundancy but as temporal stitching, connecting past, present, and future across dispersed digital spaces.

From a language and social psychology perspective, temporal anchoring works as a multimodal mnemonic device: verbal markers such as dates, anniversaries, and seasonal rituals interact with visual cues of place to encode collective memory in culturally recognizable forms. Repetition plays a central role in this process. Through repeated hashtags, recurring imagery, and iterative visual narratives, memory is stabilized against erasure and made durable across time and platforms. Digital repetition reinforces this encoding, producing a dispersed yet coherent sense of collective presence that sustains national identity beyond territorial boundaries (Shehadeh, 2023). Campaigns such as *#TweetYourThobe* and *#MyHistoricalThobe* exemplify how family heritage, ancestral homes, and cultural rituals are repeatedly invoked to root contemporary expression in

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deep historical time (Abu-Ayyash, 2024). In this way, repetition functions not as redundancy but as mnemonic labor—an ongoing process through which meaning is reaffirmed, circulated, and sustained.

This practice aligns with what De Cesari (2019) terms “memory work,” in which political claims are embedded within persistent acts of representation rather than singular moments of visibility. As Freelon et al. (2020) note, such networked temporality can counter the short attention cycles of platform economies by allowing meanings to accrue through recurrence. In this sense, repetition operates as a form of mnemonic resistance: a way of securing cultural presence through sustained visibility rather than episodic spectacle. Across our dataset, posts tied to everyday life and collective memory—rather than exceptional events alone—generated disproportionately high engagement, suggesting that temporal anchoring enhances both resonance and endurance. Engagement is central to how repetition becomes meaningful under algorithmic governance. Because platforms prioritize content that generates interaction, repeated motifs—children playing amid rubble, keys of return, balconies, olive trees—accrue visibility each time they evoke affective response. This cumulative interaction produces what Freelon et al. (2020) describe as *networked temporality*: meaning that stabilizes not through isolated posts but through iterative circulation and recognition. In this way, affect and visibility are mutually constitutive. Emotional resonance drives engagement, engagement drives visibility, and visibility in turn sustains the mnemonic and political force of the visual vocabulary. Thus, repetition is not only a stylistic choice but an infrastructural tactic through which countervisual narratives endure despite algorithmic suppression.

Through these practices, symbolic geographies emerge not as abstract representations but as lived, affective mappings of place. They are sustained through repetition, shared affect, and

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communal recognition, enabling Palestinians to assert continuity and belonging despite displacement and constraint. In this way, symbolic geographies function as infrastructures of memory and identity, anchoring political presence in the ongoing circulation of images, stories, and shared visual codes.

Conclusion

This study advances a formal understanding of how digital resistance operates through everyday visual practices by conceptualizing symbolic geographies as a central mechanism through which place, memory, and political belonging are articulated online. By examining how Palestinian Instagram users mobilize images, captions, and spatial references, we show that symbolic geographies function as affective and communicative infrastructures through which countervisual narratives are produced, circulated, and sustained. Rather than treating visual content as expressive artifacts alone, our analysis demonstrates how meaning emerges through patterned repetition, shared cultural codes, and the strategic circulation of images that render place legible under conditions of erasure. The interaction between affective resonance and algorithmic circulation underscores that visibility itself is a political terrain. The symbolic geographies we document persist because they are repeatedly recognized, engaged with, and recirculated under conditions where visibility is precarious. Engagement, in this sense, is part of the work through which Palestinians collectively secure presence in digital spaces marked by infrastructural constraint.

Conceptually, this study contributes to scholarship on digital resistance by integrating insights from countervisuality, digital placemaking, and affective publics into a unified analytical framework. We show that symbolic geographies provide a connective lens through which these

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traditions can be understood as mutually constitutive rather than discrete. In doing so, we advance theoretical understandings of how visual practices operate not only as representations of place, but as mechanisms that actively produce spatial belonging and historical continuity. Importantly, we demonstrate that symbolic geographies function as repeatable, recognizable, and affectively charged forms of communication that enable political meaning to circulate under conditions of surveillance and algorithmic constraint.

Our analysis also opens several avenues for future research. While this study highlights how visual practices sustain presence and counter erasure, it does not fully resolve the tensions embedded in what counts as "humanizing" representation. Future work could examine how certain visual tropes—such as images of children, domestic life, or moments of joy—operate simultaneously as strategies of resistance and as forms of legibility shaped by dominant humanitarian and colonial frames. As Butler (2016) argues, regimes of visibility determine which lives are recognized as grievable and which remain outside the bounds of moral concern. In this sense, humanizing imagery may both challenge dehumanization and risk reproducing hierarchies of recognition that privilege innocence, vulnerability, or relatability as conditions for empathy. Building on decolonial feminist critiques, future research could interrogate how such representations intersect with what Lugones (2010) describes as the coloniality of humanity—the production of differential value across lives—and how appeals to care and sympathy may reinscribe uneven forms of recognition. Similarly, as Ticktin (2017) notes, humanitarian frames often mobilize innocence as a moral currency, producing distinctions between "worthy" and "unworthy" subjects of care. Examining how Palestinian users navigate, resist, or strategically engage these visual economies would deepen understanding of the ambivalent politics of visibility in digital resistance. Methodologically, future studies could extend this work by

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examining how audiences interpret and respond to these representations, including how engagement metrics intersect with affective recognition and moral judgment. Longitudinal and comparative analyses across platforms or geopolitical contexts could further illuminate how symbolic geographies shift over time and under varying conditions of censorship, violence, and visibility.

In summary, this study demonstrates that symbolic geographies offer a powerful lens for understanding how digital activism transforms everyday media practices into infrastructures of political meaning. Through repetition, affect, and collective recognition, digital images become more than representations: they become mechanisms through which communities assert presence, sustain memory, and contest erasure in an increasingly mediated world.

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Ethical considerations

Conducting research on Palestinian social media during an ongoing humanitarian crisis requires careful attention to ethical, methodological, and representational issues. While this study develops a conceptual framework for symbolic geographies, it is shaped by the risks of examining digital expression under conditions of surveillance, violence, and asymmetrical power. Ethical reflexivity therefore informs both our research design and our interpretation of the data.

All Instagram materials analyzed in this study were drawn exclusively from public posts, and we did not collect or store any personally identifying information such as usernames, profile images, follower networks, or comment histories. No content behind login walls was accessed. Because user-generated posts often contain self-disclosure, personal imagery, and politically sensitive expression, we treated all posts as potentially sensitive regardless of their public visibility. Accordingly, no images are reproduced, and all examples in the manuscript or Supplementary Materials are paraphrased and stripped of contextual identifiers to minimize risks of re-identification.

Participation in the dataset is shaped by platform access, visibility, and self-selection. Although users self-identified as Palestinian, identities could not be independently verified; to mitigate this limitation, we restricted our data to posts that explicitly referenced Palestinian locations, histories, or events. We acknowledge that digital self-representation remains unevenly distributed and conditioned by structural constraints.

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Methodologically, the study combines qualitative interpretation with limited computational assistance. Machine-learning tools were used only to support multilingual translation and to help identify posts referencing Palestinian place names. These tools did not generate analytic categories or interpret meaning. All thematic coding and interpretive decisions were made manually by the research team and grounded in subjective, qualitative judgement. Because our analysis relied primarily on visual interpretation and spatial references, occasional translation inaccuracies did not affect coding: the only textual component requiring precision was the identification of place names, which were manually verified.

To avoid transmitting sensitive user content to external servers, all preprocessing and translation were conducted offline, using the open-source M2M-100 multilingual translation model (Fan et al., 2021), rather than proprietary cloud-based services.

Importantly, ChatGPT-4o was used only for classifying mainstream news headlines in the comparative press corpus—a publicly available, non-identifying textual dataset. No Instagram images, captions, or metadata were processed through proprietary AI systems. To mitigate potential geopolitical bias in the headline classification task, we manually reviewed a validation subset, documented prompts and decision rules, and provide full details in the Supplementary Materials.

AI use

ChatGPT 4-o was also used to proofread a full draft of the manuscript.

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Data Availability

The annotations for the Instagram and MediaCloud datasets (without identifiers and accompanying images) will be available to accredited researchers upon signing a non-disclosure agreement.

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Declaration of Conflict of Interests

No potential competing interest is reported by the author(s).

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